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Allen Vache

Clarinetist Allen Vache was born in New Jersey and currently makes his home in Orlando, Florida. He credits Kenny Davern as an important early influence, as well as his musical family. Allen appears frequently at jazz festivals and concerts here and abroad and his playing is well represented on recordings with the Jim Cullum Jazz Band and as a leader on the Audiophile and Nagel-Heyer Labels.

Allen was interviewed in Scottsdale, Arizona on April 15, 2000, by Monk Rowe, director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in Scottsdale, Arizona. My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Allen Vache with me today, who is a mean clarinet player.

AV: Well I don't know if it's "mean."

MR: I heard you doing some mean bending of notes in that last set that I thought was very interesting.

AV: Yeah with it's, stylistically, things borrowed from other people. I studied with Kenny Davern when I was in college, and he is one of the masters of the note benders, let's put it that way.

MR: He's almost the standard of how people get measured these days.

AV: Yeah, right.

MR: As far as contemporary jazz players. Whatever possessed you to try and make this a living?

AV: Oh gosh. Well I come from a musical family. My brother is a professional musician, my father was at one point a professional musician but felt he couldn't support a family on it so ended up just working weekends and stuff and playing. He played at Nick's and Condon's back in the '30s and so forth. And at this particular point I would say I can't think of anything else that I could have done. I had never had any interest in anything else. I mean I listened to this kind of music since before I knew what I was listening to, when I was a baby in the crib. So it never occurred to me to do anything else.

MR: It's interesting, those early impressions, that they take root with some people and with some people they don't. You must have had an inherent music talent that latched on to that kind of jazz music.

AV: Yeah I would guess so. It's all abstract, so it's kind of hard to really pin down. But on the same token I would think that both my brother and I inherited some form of musical talent that gravitated us toward this kind of music, for improvisational music especially. It's really kind of hard to explain.

MR: Yeah. Well you were born when?

AV: 1953.

MR: Okay, so the music that was being played most prevalently on the radio by the time you were really aware of it, would have been like early rock & roll I suppose.

AV: Yeah, absolutely.

MR: But also things like Peggy Lee and Ray Conniff and all that. But what did you hear in your house?

AV: Well again, my dad had a humungous record collection that we listened to constantly and I heard anything from the swing era bands to early Dixieland bands and Eddie Condon style. And actually it was very funny because when my brother and I went through our adolescent rebellion in our early pre-teens and teens, our rebellion against our father was buying Miles Davis records and Charlie Parker records, which he didn't care for because that was the music that they ruined after he came back from World War II.

MR: I see. Look what they've done to my song, right? That's funny. You know most teenagers, their rebellion is Steppenwolf or something.

AV: Exactly. That's what all my friends, that's what they listened to, you know, and their parents hated it. I was listening to Charlie Parker records and my father hated it.

MR: But you eventually — correct me if I'm wrong, please — but your tastes maybe worked backwards again?

AV: Yeah, pretty much. I mean I spent a lot of time listening to Benny Goodman records, and becoming a clarinetist especially. What's available to listen to, as opposed to because during the bop era, when bop became real popular, there weren't too many clarinet players anymore. The clarinet players were Goodman and Shaw and those guys, the guys who led the big bands. But there are a lot more saxophone players because there were five saxophones in every big band, and usually only one clarinet player if any at all. So there were a lot more saxophone players so therefore the saxophone became more of a common instrument. But there were still Buddy DeFranco and Tony Scott and a few other guys who were playing the clarinet and playing it bop, so I've been influenced by that but I know a few of those tunes but my sense of improvisation never really gravitated to that style of music, not that I don't love it, just like I like to listen to a Mozart symphony but I wouldn't be very good playing it.

MR: What was your classical training on the clarinet?

AV: I studied with David Dworkin, who was a clarinetist with the Metropolitan Opera Orchestra. And it was the same situation, I was studying in college, I went to Jersey City State, which is a music college in Jersey City, New Jersey. That's where I grew up was New Jersey. So I studied with him and I studied some with Herbert Blamin who was the principal clarinetist with the opera orchestra, the Metropolitan Opera Orchestra. But both

of them were well aware that I was not interested in becoming a symphonic player or anything, so I would play things that were more jazz oriented — works like Ravel or Alec Wilder or composers like that. That's what they would have me do because they would tell me, you're not going to be a classical musician, what's the point of learning the standard repertoire. If you want to learn to just play the instrument we're here to teach you how to play the instrument better so you can do the things that you want. They were both very good teachers. And at the same time that's when I was studying with Kenny.

MR: How did he teach you to play jazz?

AV: Well he never really taught me to play jazz. You really can't teach anybody to play jazz.

MR: Well that was my next question.

AV: I mean what he did is kind of steer me in the right direction. As a matter of fact I was with him in Sarasota at the Sarasota festival a couple of weeks ago and we were talking about this, because it was thirty years ago you know, practically thirty years ago. And he says, "The way I remember it is that you used to come over to the house and I'd show you a couple of exercises that will help you in your upper register, and then we'd sit down and I'd mix martinis and we'd sit and listen to records for about two or three hours." And that's basically what we did. And we would listen to records and he would say, "Now you see what this guy is doing here, see what this is going on here?" And we spent a lot more time hanging out and listening than we actually did playing. But I learned a lot. And he would show me certain fingerings, some of the upper register fingerings that I use, that I've become kind of like himself, known for my upper register ability. And most of that stuff is things that he showed me, that he developed himself. So I owe a lot to Kenny.

MR: Yeah. When you say you can't teach jazz, how do you respond or react to all the jazz methods and the university programs and all that kind of thing that are out there now?

AV: Well I think they're all very good. I think you can teach the basics, the understanding. My biggest problem with most of them is that somebody writes a book and says here are all Charlie Parker's solos. Once you learn these then you'll be a jazz player. I mean it doesn't really work that way. And they don't really put enough emphasis on listening to people, listening to players that came before. My biggest problem with most jazz education programs is they act like nothing happened before Charlie Parker or Dizzy Gillespie. And there was a lot of great music being made. There was Louis Armstrong, there was Benny Goodman, I mean Jack Teagarden, guys who created great things from nothing. Charlie Parker and Dizzy will tell you the first thing that they did is they listened to — Dizzy listened to Roy Eldridge, Charlie Parker listened to Lester Young and Jimmy Dorsey. But these people, they don't really want to know that there was anything going

on before that. I mean if you want to hear something innovative put on Louis' duet record with Earl Hines doing "Weatherbird Rag." It's the most amazing thing I've ever heard.

MR: And it's like you said, it came from nothing.

AV: That's right. They didn't have anybody to listen to. They came up with it all by themselves.

MR: Yeah. Interesting. Did you and your brother have any kind of sibling rivalry going with the music?

AV: Oh yes and no. We still have a little bit. But as we get older it kind of wanes in the noonday sun, as O. Henry said. We've learned to live with each other a little bit. But my brother has a tendency to be a little bit high strung. His temper can sometimes get the best of him. We've had our hassles over the years but basically we still get along pretty well. And we just did a record for this label that I record on, Nagel-Heyer Records, and this is "Mrs. Vache's Boys," that's been selling very well, it just got voted number two in *Jazz Journal International* for 1999. So we're both pretty proud of it.

MR: You don't call each other up every week and say so how many gigs did you have this week?

AV: No, no. I just worked with him a couple of weeks ago in Florida and we had a little row with each other but he was not feeling well, he was sick and he didn't really want to be at the gig. It's a typical thing. So we may have like five minutes of tension and then everything, oh, well, forget about it man.

MR: And your father was supportive in you guys going in this direction?

AV: Yeah, very much so. I worked with so many friends who tell me how their parents were very much opposed to them going into becoming professional musicians because this business is a crap shoot. Whether or not you're going to be able to make a living at it is very questionable, and a lot of guys can't make a living at it. I have to say that I consider myself fairly lucky. When I was 22 I took a steady job, stayed there for 17 years, and worked with a band working in a night club six nights a week and traveling, the Jim Cullum Jazz Band in San Antonio. So I was with them for 17 years. And I mean I got pretty burned out on it after so many years and I left. And I figured I was taking a pretty good chance, because here I was, I was off the circuit for a long time and then trying to break into the circuit. I had a couple of fairly lean years. But I was lucky enough that — I like to think that maybe my ability had something to do with it — but I was able to eventually break into the circuit and do pretty well. I'm not getting rich, but so far I don't have any bill collectors pounding on my doors so I can't complain too much. If you can do that I think you do okay in this business.

MR: Someone was asking me the other day what's the definition of making it big? Sometimes kids use that phrase. And I think you almost just defined it. If you're doing what you love, that's a big step right there.

AV: Well it's like the joke what do you call a jazz musician without a girlfriend? Homeless. It's funny but unfortunately in many cases it's true.

MR: Jim Cullum is kind of dedicated to keeping alive a certain genre of music?

AV: Yes and no. It's definitely more of a traditional style that he goes for. But over the years that I was on the band we experimented and did a lot of different things. We never got into doing hardcore bop or anything like that. We moved into swing and mainstream quite a bit and did some of those kind of things. And we did that National Public Radio show that I was on for five years.

MR: The Riverwalk series?

AV: Riverwalk, yeah. And we got into many different styles of playing, depending on a lot of times we had different guest stars and stuff — like we were doing big band swing when Jay McShann was there, we were doing all of Hootie's big hits, which was that period, and talking about Charlie Parker and so forth. So it just depended. And all the guys on the band are great musicians and fairly — can adapt to that style. I ended up having to play saxophone more on a lot of those things too, I was playing alto and so forth. Bob Wilber came in, he and I did a couple of duets on saxophone, soprano and alto, and that kind of thing. So it's not really what Jim wants to keep the band doing, but on the same token, for that particular show you can't just stay in one area you have to be able to expand some. Otherwise you're going to lose the interest of the audience.

MR: Right. I think Joe Williams appeared on that.

AV: Yeah, that was later on. I'm very disappointed, I was gone by the time Joe appeared on the show and it would have been great.

MR: Well when you describe leaving that situation to go on the circuit, can you describe to me what circuit exists now for you?

AV: Well I think there's a handful of about 50 to 100 guys who are traveling around the world doing different jazz oriented things within the spectrum of the music that we're listening to right now, doing these kind of jazz parties, festivals, here in the States and in Europe. And you might see my name on one or two of them and you'll see somebody else's name on two or three, but next year you might see that reversed. And so that's basically what I'm talking about. Like I've done a festival or a party where I'm there one year and then I don't come back for a couple of years, and they've got Kenny or they've got Bob Wilber or they've got Abe Most or they've got — they always get one or two clarinetists — Harry Allen does tons of them. Plus doing different tours of people who bring bands over for tours in Europe and so forth and so on. There's a couple of guys in Germany. Butch

and I were like eight weeks in Germany a couple of years ago, on the bus doing one-nighters all through the country.

MR: With pick-up rhythm sections?

AV: Well no, it was like one of these all-star bands — it was Bob Haggart and Butch and Johnny Varro and Bob Havens and myself, Ed Polcer. I can't remember all the guys on the band. But it was about an eight or nine piece band.

MR: Any reaction to the music over there?

AV: Yeah generally you get a much more enthusiastic reaction than you do here in the States. Plus you will find the ages of the audience are much more diversified than they are here. As a general rule you don't see a lot of people my age, or under the age of 60 at a lot of these festivals and parties that I do here in the States, but you do in Europe.

MR: It's rather a shame.

AV: It is rather a shame. It concerns me. Because I wonder what's going to happen say 20 or 25 years from now.

MR: What is the likelihood of when you come to these gigs that you get in a situation where you don't know enough tunes.

AV: Oh, constantly. Constantly. We all have the same situation.

MR: No kidding?

AV: Oh yeah.

MR: Just as an observer, from what I've seen it always seem like you guys aren't at a loss but I'm almost glad to hear that you're human in that sense.

AV: Oh sure, sure. This weekend I was a little concerned because there's a lot of what I would consider more contemporary, modern players here at this, than I'm used to doing on these things. And I'm somewhat a little concerned that the guys are going to start calling up some heavy bebop things and I'm going to say gee guys, I don't really know those. And it's not that I haven't heard them, it's just that I never really took the time to learn them because I never really had to before.

MR: Yeah, and the heads on those tunes can be —

AV: Yeah, you've got to play them exact otherwise it's not right. I'd really have to sit down and practice a little bit. But you know generally, the thing about this is everybody is — nobody is out to get anybody else. We're not out to see if we can nail this guy or nail that guy. We're all here to have a good time and try to celebrate the music as best as we can and present it in the best possible way to the audience who is paying the bills for us to see. So I mean we'll all get together — if one guy says well gee I really don't know that tune, they'll say okay, well let's pick something else.

MR: Is there any kind of racial disharmony in the music these days that you're aware of with the players?

AV: I think there is a little bit but I really haven't experienced any of it, okay. I have seen situations where — well I don't want to criticize anyone, but I mean a situation like the Lincoln Center Jazz Ensemble that Wynton Marsalis has, and they're trying to do more traditional jazz, and many of the guys are not that familiar with the traditional styles of music but they are given the job because they are not white players, they are black players. I think that's unfortunate. But in all the traveling that I do and all the guys that I've worked with over the years, black or white, everybody is always on everybody else's side. I mean Wendell Brunious is here, Wendell is a wonderful player. I love working with Wendell, he plays great. I mean Ray Brown, a monster.

MR: Yeah this festival seems to be —

AV: I don't really — and I've traveled with Milt Hinton extensively and Milt is the most wonderful guy in the world and always very supportive. On a one-to-one basis I have never experienced it I'm happy to say. And I hope that it would be less and less as time goes on. Because I have experienced — I was in a thing with doing a clinic a year or so ago at UCLA with Kenny Burrell and guys were asking us questions, and this one guy kept saying, "Since jazz is an African-American art form, I mean where do you get off playing this music" and this kind of thing. And I really had to say to the guy, you know, your history's a little off. Because jazz is not an African-American art form. What it is that makes it uniquely American is it's a merging of African-American music and European music, and that's what made it more unique, plus Creole influences of New Orleans. And because it all happened in New Orleans and the merging of all these different styles of music, that's what created it. That's what made it uniquely American. I said it's not just the music of one race. That's what's so great about it. It's exactly the opposite of everything that was going on in the south at the time.

MR: That's a good point. And depending on what history writer you read, sometimes you'll get that opinion and sometimes you won't.

AV: Well I mean if you read about the early history of the music from the guys who actually did it, for instance, Alan Lomax's book about Jelly Roll Morton called *Mr. Jelly Lord*. Jelly Roll Morton. It's basically taken from tapes of Jelly Roll Morton talking about the music, and him saying well yeah, we listened to the European musicians and we had such-and-such and Tony Parenti was there, and Tony Parenti was an Italian guy, and so forth. And that's what it was. It was a combination of the African sounds and rhythms and so forth, but also with European styles and European scales and the music that was developed in Europe. So like I said it's what made it so unique. I mean if you were going to try to sit there and say this is strictly an African music, it's not. Because you go to Africa and you listen to what they're doing, they're not doing jazz. They're doing things that jazz had a lot of roots in, but it's not jazz. Jazz was something that was formed

uniquely there because of the combination of the different ideas and the different musical concepts.

MR: All right. Well said. A little earlier we were kind of joking about the theory behind music and how it's sometimes overdone and the mode thing and all that. Is it possible for you to describe your thinking process when you improvise, and how much of it is affected by your knowledge or lack of knowledge of chord structure and all that?

AV: Oh it's affected very much by my knowledge of chord structure and my ear, to be able to hear chord changes. And everything that I do improvisational-wise is — everybody does it differently. Everybody thinks differently. The way I think is chordally by an extension of the chords. For instance, I think, if it's a G seven chord I may play the ninth or the flatted ninth or the lowered fifth or these kind of things. And move into the next change. I used to know a guy in New York who used to teach an improvisational course and he would teach the kids learning chord changes by thinking they were changing keys. Okay, now for a while if you've got a two-five-seven in B flat, you're in B flat. But now the next chord change is a two-five-seven in G you now change to the key of G, and so forth and so on. It worked for some of them. It never worked for me. Because it confused me. So my approach to it was always what the chord changes are, and working around those changes and embellishing those changes. I mean it may not be written a G nine, but you can play a ninth on top of a G seven, that kind of thing. And that's basically the way I've always approached it. And what goes on in my mind is I see the notes as if I was actually reading them on a page. But up to a certain point. I see some of them. I don't see all of them.

MR: I like that analogy. Right. Because you can almost hear some of them but not quite all of them.

AV: Exactly. You've got to have a couple in the middle before you get to the next one.

MR: To get where that thing is you can hear. Yeah, those are the passing tones, right?

AV: Yeah, right.

MR: Do you have experience with the piano?

AV: Yeah. I started on piano. Both my brother and I took piano lessons when we were kids. My father insisted on it. And it's the one thing that he really did for us — he insisted, no matter what we played he said it would give you a basis of understanding the music. My brother actually plays better piano than I do because he kept on practicing. I never did.

MR: What do you envision down the road. Do you think ten years ahead for yourself, and the future of this music?

AV: Well as I said before, Monk, I'm a little concerned about the future of this music and I try not to think about ten years down the road. I try to look at things year by year. If the phone keeps ringing I'm in good shape. And so far, so good. But what happens, in ten

years, gee I don't really know. I am concerned about it. I live in the Orlando area so I worked at Walt Disney World some, sub out there with other bands and stuff like that. What concerns me is I envision myself ending up having to try to get a regular job at Walt Disney World because I can't make a living any other way. Hopefully not.

MR: The state of jazz on the radio, and stuff that's coming out currently, does it affect your own playing much? Do you listen to the contemporary young guys playing?

AV: Yes, constantly. And I will say that there seems to be more jazz on the radio now than there was say ten years ago. But most of the stations are public radio stations or college stations and so forth. In Orlando we have WUCF which is an excellent jazz station. Now it depends on what you're talking about. If you're talking about the stuff that they call smooth jazz, no, I don't listen to that stuff at all. I don't consider that jazz, I consider that a kind of a smooth form of rock & roll. Because I don't know who said it, but to me if a player does not have a natural sense of swing in his playing, if the phrasing isn't swinging, then it's not worth listening to as a jazz player. And all the great players, no matter where they went in an extension, I mean from Parker to Coltrane to Coleman, Ornette Coleman or any of these guys, even though how far they extended their improvisation, everything still swung its ass off. I mean Coltrane could swing like a mother. And he did constantly. It may not be necessarily the way I would think or somebody else would think because he was constantly innovative and creating new things. But he was still always swinging. And that stuff, like let's face it, Kenny G can't swing his way out of a paper bag, we all know it, everybody knows it. But that's not what those people are listening for. They're listening to — nice background music while you're lighting candles at dinner. But the other stations, the public radio stations, college stations, like WUCF in Orlando that I listen to constantly, I have it on my car radio all the time, and they're nice. They play some of my records, they play a lot of local artists there, there's some really good players from the Orlando area, John Allred, a wonderful trombone player, and a few others. And we all have recorded. They play a lot of local artists plus they play a lot of national things. And within the spectrum of a very good — a very long spectrum of music, from classic and traditional all the way up to super-contemporary things that are going on today. It's worth listening to. Not everything I enjoy, but I like the idea that these guys are willing to take a chance and play the whole entire spectrum, instead of saying well we're not going to play anything that was done before 1950, which a lot of places do, a lot of stations do.

MR: What's it like trying to find outlets for recording these days? You get hooked up with a good label and try to stay with them?

AV: Exactly. I'm lucked into a wonderful situation with a label in Germany.

MR: Nagel-Heyer?

AV: Nagel-Heyer, yeah. And they have been wonderful to me. I do between one and two records a year for them. They promote my records, they do all they can, they spend a lot of money in advertising, they hired Allegro Distribution to distribute the records all through so they're now like in Borders bookstores and Sound Warehouse and Tower Records and all these places. I mean I can't say enough good things about them, they are the sweetest, nicest people in the world, and they are just trying to promote good music on records and have done a wonderful job.

MR: Cool.

AV: And there again, they're trying to record the entire spectrum of the music. They just did a great thing with Wycliffe Gordon, and they have no prejudices. They like good musicians and good music. Again I can't say enough good things — it's another thing that I consider myself a very lucky person to have met them.

MR: Do you do a certain amount of your own promotion to try to keep your name — I mean even like a place like this — do you try to make sure that the promoter doesn't forget about you or is it not necessary? Do you think you're in the circuit enough that —

AV: Yeah I think so. I do a certain amount of promotion personally on certain things. Like I have a website, a web page, and I have a little quartet group that Phil Flanigan plays with, we were talking about Phil before, and a couple of guys from Florida. We try to do tributes to the things that Sidney Bechet and Muggsy Spanier did in the 40s, with just guitar and bass and cornet and clarinet. And we have been trying to promote that some more to get some more work for it, but other than that, the rest of it, a lot of this business is through word of mouth and through recordings. People hear your records and they say oh gee, this is a good guy, let's get this guy, and that's kind of the way it works. So I would say the things that have helped me promotionally-wise within the last five years has been the Riverwalk radio show, because they still do a lot of re-runs and I'm on the show still quite a bit. They do compilation shows too, so I may have recorded a whole show and now I'll listen to it and I'll hear myself for like two tunes and then somebody else. Plus, and the record label, because since I've done a lot of recording for them in the last five years. I've got about oh I'd say six or seven CDs out so far in the last five years. Maybe even a little bit more than that. Because I've also done some things as sideman for other guys.

MR: These parties here are almost like you have your own little fan club sometimes. I see all the people come up, and, "I saw you in Sarasota" and, "would you sign this." It's a nice situation.

AV: Yeah that's what happens. It's nice, and you do run across some of the same people. And like I was saying earlier, I was telling Harry Allen, this is a little different situation for me, this particular party, and some of the things, I mean a lot of the guys, a lot of the

parties I work, they don't extend this far into more contemporary music than this party is doing. Because again, these people are very opinionated about what style of music they like. And they don't want it to get over that way. But these guys here are extending the envelope a little bit. But it makes me feel a little bit of a fish out of water because I'm not so sure I fit in with everything that is going on. But I do my best, and I figure a lot of people seem to enjoy the way I play so I'm going to do what I do, and if you like it fine, well if you don't like it, okay, I'm sorry, I did the best I could.

MR: We might even have a little Latin here at this gig.

AV: Yeah I know. Well you've got one of the greatest Latin players in the business, Dave Valentin. And boy what a monster he is man.

MR: I'm looking forward to that.

AV: But there again all the guys, all the musicians, nobody's out to get everybody. We're all on everybody's side. We had a little party of Don Miller's last night and Dave and Charlie Sepluveda got up and played a real heavy, Latin, modern thing you know, and then Don says, "Allen, you want to come up and play?" And I'm like, "You know guys, I really don't know any of that stuff, I just know some kind of standard tunes." And Roland Hanna and Jay Leonhart say, "Allen, play whatever you want." Bill Watrous, "Whatever you want, don't worry about it, man. So you don't have to worry about being challenged or somebody out to get you, because it's not that way, and it shouldn't be that way. This is not a competition. That's my biggest problem with, you talk about jazz education people. That's my biggest problem is they set up this thing that's kind of a competition. There isn't enough of us to be out to get each other. We should be on everybody else's side.

MR: Did you ever crack into the New York scene at all?

AV: Well yeah, well I grew up in the New York/New Jersey area, and I worked Eddie Condon's for quite a while, and I've always been kind of in and out of the New York scene even though I live in Florida. I just don't like living in New York. It's not one of my favorite places. And it's not the same place I grew up in. There's not as much going on in New York as when I was a kid in the 60s and 70s. I mean there was a lot more going on then than there is now. There's not very much of a club scene there anymore. I mean the clubs that you do go in — you work The Cajun on 34th Street, and they pay you forty dollars. It's really pretty sad. But most of the guys who are in the scene, I have known and I've worked with back in the early 70s and the late 60s, and I've always kept in touch with them. And a lot of the guys I work with, a lot of them are out of New York. I usually go back there once or twice a year and work some of the clubs that are in New Jersey or New York, just to keep my hand in and let everybody know I'm still around. But living in Florida too is a lot better than when I was in Texas. There's a pretty good

scene in Florida, a lot of good players down in Florida, Flip Phillips and Bill and John Allred, a lot of great players, Johnny Varro, a lot of guys around there, so there's a lot more going on there.

MR: Did you ever have occasion to associate with Sol Yaged by any chance?

AV: Oh I know Sol very well, yeah. Very interesting guy.

MR: We saw him a couple of months ago, I was just curious if you knew him.

AV: Yeah I know Sol. Sol's a nice guy. He's a good player, and he's a little bit odd but he's still a very nice guy. And I've always thought he was a great player. He's really got all that Benny stuff down. I mean he's a real heavy student of Benny, to the point of Benny's actions, like dropping the right shoulder and this kind of thing. Sol's got it all down.

MR: Indeed he does. Well if you had to make a list of what you consider the top five clarinetists in jazz, could you? Would you want to?

AV: I wouldn't want to, and I don't think I could. I could probably make you a list of the top two hundred, you know. I mean especially if we say living or dead. If you want to say living, I mean maybe I could pick ten guys. But if you want to say living or dead, it would be impossible. I mean you could go from early guys like Omar Simeon and Leon Rappolo to the guys like Tony Scott. I mean in my opinion everybody plays a little differently, and there's always something that you can borrow or steal. Basically what I'm saying is there's always something you can learn from somebody else, if they play good, and it doesn't matter. I mean I spent a lot of time as a kid listening to saxophone players as much as I listened to clarinet players because I mean it's amazing the things you can learn listening to Lester Young or John Coltrane or Charlie Parker or Coleman Hawkins or any one of these guys. I mean they're still doing the same things that you want to do, it doesn't matter that they're playing a different instrument. And the instruments aren't that different. It's just that there's more saxophone players than there are clarinet players.

MR: You've got more range.

AV: I do, I do. It's one of the reasons — I mean I play saxophone, but I don't really spend a lot of time working on it where I could actually be what I would consider a good saxophone player because I don't have that interest in the instrument. But I listen to a guy like Harry Allen and I think now if I wanted to play the saxophone, that's the way I'd want to play it. It's an instrument that confines me. I feel like I have more range and more things that I can do on the clarinet and that's what I want to do. So far nobody's complained too much. I do still have to take big band gigs where I have to double a little bit but I sit there and I read the parts on the tenor saxophone, then the jazz parts come up and I play the clarinet.

MR: Right. Do you do any teaching at all?

AV: I did. I don't anymore. I did. My fiance, she is a Juilliard graduate, a master of Juilliard and she plays clarinet, she's a clarinetist too, and she's got quite a few students. Basically she plays some with the Orlando Philharmonic, but she also goes to different schools and teaches for the high school kids and so forth. And she really likes teaching. I always hated teaching. I mean I worked at a couple of music studios and I would sit and let the kids play and just sit there and just look at my watch for the thirty minutes because I was so bored and so unhappy. It's nothing I really enjoyed doing. And I've had some people call me and ask me for like improvisional lessons and stuff like that and I'm like well gee, here's a couple of books that will teach you some chord changes, and go out and buy 200 records and you can save yourself a lot of money in buying lessons from me.

MR: And throw in a gin and tonic like you and Kenny used to, right?

AV: Yeah. Exactly.

MR: Well I wish you the best and I hope in ten years, as you said, that jazz is still healthy enough.

AV: I hope so too.

MR: That you are able to keep doing what you're doing.

AV: You know I have to be somewhat optimistic and say that I think it will, because it's lasted a lot longer than a lot of people thought it was going to last now, and just hopefully it will appeal to a younger generation — at least maintain the status quo that it has now.

MR: Well it's become an art form for sure, considered to be an art form of American culture, which is a good thing. Sometimes I wish there was still the club scene that there used to be, at least as far as training grounds.

AV: Yeah. You see I had that. It's a shame about what there is today because kids coming up really don't have that any longer. I mean like I can remember going and sitting in clubs when I was a kid, and it was kind of a sink or swim situation and either you learned or you didn't. Sometimes you weren't treated so well if you didn't do too well. But it was a good leaning experience and the next time you showed up you made sure you knew the tune and you were in better shape and better prepared.

MR: Well enjoy the rest of the weekend.

AV: Well thanks Monk. I appreciate your—

MR: We'll be looking for you at other events.

AV: Well thanks very much.

MR: Is there anything that I didn't talk about that you'd like to add?

AV: No I don't think so. You covered everything pretty well.

MR: All right.

AV: All right, thanks very much.

MR: Thanks a lot.